
Yves Congar and "Lumen gentium"

Author(s): William Henn

Source: *Gregorianum*, 2005, Vol. 86, No. 3 (2005), pp. 563-592

Published by: GBPress- Gregorian Biblical Press

Stable URL: <https://www.jstor.org/stable/23582406>

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Yves Congar and *Lumen gentium*

Several days before the promulgation of Vatican II's «Dogmatic Constitution on the Church», a prospective doctoral student from Poland approached council *peritus* Yves Congar to ask about writing a dissertation on the latter's ecclesiology. In his private diary, Congar followed the note he made about this encounter with three explanation marks, adding «I have not done an ecclesiology».¹ What a striking statement by a theologian who doubtless would be listed among the greatest proponents of Twentieth Century Catholic ecclesiology. He certainly was modest, even to a fault. But perhaps, in addition to his characteristic modesty, one reason for such a denial can be gleaned from Jared Wicks' fine synthesis of Congar's recently published journals. Wicks pointed out that, in the years after the Second World War, Congar had hoped to follow his two 'preliminary works' on reform in the Church and on the laity (his famous *Vraie et fausse réforme dans l'Église* of 1950 and his ground-breaking *Jalons pour une théologie du laïcat* of 1953) with his own *De ecclesia*, which he had intended to entitle *Église, peuple de Dieu et mystiquement corps du Christ*.² Because of the suspicion he was experiencing in those years from certain officials in the Vatican, his literary production was carefully scrutinized and often delayed, one result being that this systematic ecclesiology was never written. Nevertheless, Congar's spontaneous reaction recorded in his journal was surely exaggerated.³ Indeed, at the beginning of March, 1963, he was quickly

¹ Y. CONGAR, *Mon journal du Concile*, II, Paris, 2002, 259: «Je suis empêché d'écouter Baraniak par un Polonais qui veut faire une thèse sur mon ecclésiologie (et celle de K. Rahner)!!! Il veut venir à Strasbourg pour m'entendre...!!! Mon Dieu!!! Je n'ai pas fait d'ecclésiologie». This entry appears under the date 13 Novembre 1964; *Lumen gentium* was promulgated eight days later.

² So J. WICKS, «Yves Congar's Doctrinal Service of the People of God» in *Gregorianum* 84 (2003) 499-550 at 508-509. Wicks' source for this information is Congar's *Journal d'un théologien 1946-1956*, Paris, 2001, 57. On March 19, 1966, Congar noted in his journal that people continued to ask him when his *De ecclesia* would come out; – cf. *Mon journal*, II, 525.

³ In fact, other passages from his journal acknowledge his considerable command of ecclesiology. In *Mon journal du Concile*, I, Paris, 2002, 8, writing in July of 1960, before he actually attended his first session of the preparatory theological commission, he notes: «Je commence à connaître assez bien l'histoire de l'ecclésiologie». Two years later he would com-

enlisted to work on the sub-commission charged with producing the text which would eventually become *Lumen gentium*, precisely because of the quality and depth of his understanding of the Church and of the history of ecclesiology. Charles Moeller, of the decisively effective Belgian group of council participants, insisted that a good *De ecclesia* could not be produced without the collaboration of Congar.⁴

One can argue that trying to specify the contribution of a bishop or theologian to any of the documents of Vatican II, each of which is the result of a complex process of discussion and revision, risks giving a very false impression.⁵ Moreover, the contribution of a figure like Congar has a unified and global quality which was brought to bear upon many different issues at the council; focusing on just one document can obscure the over-arching contribution which he brought to all of the texts on which he worked.⁶ Many of the studies which have so far appeared about Congar's activity at Vatican II have tended to look at his overall contribution, without focusing on any particular document.⁷ Nevertheless, if one is alerted to the pitfalls of attributing too much influence to one individual in the production of a given text or of obscuring his overall contribution, it seems both legitimate and valuable to try to bring into clearer focus just how one participant's theology and conciliar activity may have left their marks on a particular docu-

ment that his experience on the commission confirmed his fundamental intuitions about that history; cf. *Mon journal*, I, 179-180. When he was received in private audience by Pope Paul VI on June 8, 1964, he presented to the Holy Father the following books which he had recently published: *Sainte Église*, Paris, 1963; *Chrétiens en dialogue*, Paris, 1964; *La tradition et les traditions. Essai historique*, Paris, 1960; *La tradition et les traditions. Essai théologique*, Paris, 1963; *La foi et la théologie*, Tournai, 1962; *Le Concile au jour le jour*, Paris 1963; *Le Concile au jour le jour. Deuxième session*, Paris, 1964; and *Pour une Église servante et pauvre*, Paris, 1963; cf. *Mon journal*, II, 115. Even as the final session of Vatican II was coming to a close, on December 6-7, 1965, Congar was polishing up his work on the four notes of the Church, *L'Église une, sainte, catholique, et apostolique*, which was later published as volume 15 of the multi-volumed *Mysterium salutis*, Paris, 1970; cf. *Mon journal*, II, 506 and 508. Finally, he was one of the featured participants at a symposium held for Dominican ecclesiologists in Valencia, Spain, in early March of 1966; cf. *Mon journal*, II, 524-526. A fine demonstration of Congar's pre-conciliar work in ecclesiology is J. FAMERÉE, *Histoire et Église. L'ecclésiologie du père Congar de «Chrétiens désunis» à l'annonce de concile (1937-1959)*, Louvain-la-Neuve, 1991.

⁴ So É. FOUILLLOUX, «Comment devient-on expert à Vatican II ? Le cas du Père Yves Congar» in *Le deuxième concile du Vatican (1959-1965)*, Rome, 1989, 330.

⁵ So J. BUNNENBERG, «Der Einfluß Congars auf die Konzilskonstitution *Dei verbum*» in ID., *Lebendige Treue zum Ursprung. Das Traditionsverständnis Yves Congars*, Mainz, 1989, 275.

⁶ The latter view is espoused by AL. MELLONI in his «Yves Congar à Vatican II. Hypothèses et pistes de recherche» in A. VAUCHEZ (éd.), *Cardinal Yves Congar 1904-1995. Actes du colloque réuni à Rome les 3-4 juin 1996*, Paris, 1999, 117-164 at 120-121.

⁷ In addition to the works cited above by Wicks, Fouilloux and Melloni, one might add my own «Yves Congar al Vaticano II» in *Communio* 142 (luglio-agosto 1995) 59-68 and É. MAHIEU, «Introduction» to *Mon journal*, I, XXV-LXVII. The chapter of Bunnenberg cited in note 5 is an exception to this trend.

ment. The following essay will attempt to do just that with regard to Yves Congar's role in the evolution of the Dogmatic Constitution on the Church.

Congar's participation in the process which produced *Lumen gentium* should be divided into three distinct phases according to the quite different roles Congar played in each of them. First comes the preparatory phase, which ran from Congar's appointment to the preparatory theological commission of the council in July of 1960 until the beginning of the council on October 11, 1962. In this first phase he felt isolated within the commission, dominated as it was by prelates and theologians living in Rome and working at the various Vatican dicasteries or theological faculties. Their theology was the target of very sharp criticisms in Congar's diary.⁸ Because his vision of the Church was so different from that of the president of the preparatory theological commission, Cardinal Ottaviani, and its secretary, Fr. Sebastian Tromp, Congar believed that his views were given no real hearing and he was even tempted at times to resign.⁹ A second phase comprises the first session of the council (October 11-December 8, 1962) and the two months immediately following it. In this period Congar served as personal *peritus* for Archbishop Jean Julien Weber of Strasbourg¹⁰ and found himself in the entirely different climate created by the gathering of and interchange among the more than two thousand members of the world-wide Catholic episcopate along with hundreds of theological advisers. He wrote glowingly about «the first conciliar action» of Vatican II, when, on Saturday, October 13, the bishops voted to postpone the vote to select the members of the various conciliar commissions so that they could get to know one another better and not vote merely upon the basis of the list of candidates which had been prepared beforehand in Rome.¹¹ For Congar, this simple action expressed the will of the bishops to deliberate freely about the various issues which would be proposed for their consideration. During this phase, Congar's activity was rather informal in nature, participating in discussions and offering lectures in response to requests from bishops or colleges of students attending the ecclesiastical faculties. Finally, a third distinct phase begins on March 1, 1963 and lasts until the actual promulgation of *Lumen*

⁸ From the very first entry in Congar's extensive council diary, one finds blunt denunciations of the way in which the Holy Office and individual members of the Vatican curia thought about the nature and mission of the Church, tried to censure Catholic theologians who thought differently and, since they had been assigned the leading positions in the various pre-conciliar commissions, would be in a position to thwart and to sabotage the council which had not yet even begun; cf. *Mon journal*, I, 3-21.

⁹ So E. FOUILLOUX, «Comment», 311, and *Mon journal*, I, 74.

¹⁰ See É. MAHIEU, «Introduction», XXXIII and XLIX.

¹¹ So his entry on the day of that vote in *Mon journal*, I, 114; a couple of days later, on Monday, October 15th, he writes: «Un des résultats du concile pourrait bien être la naissance d'une collégialité épiscopale mondiale articulée et structurée» (*Mon journal*, I, 118).

gentium, twenty-one months later. From that date, Congar served no longer as private advisor to a single Archbishop but as a member of the Council's theological commission, and, more precisely, of the sub-commission charged with elaborating a new *De ecclesia*. The version that had been prepared before the council and briefly discussed on December 1-7, 1962, was sharply criticized during the closing days of the first session. A substantially new text, different in structure and tone would be needed. Now Congar took part directly in the drafting of texts, the collation and selection of *modi*, and the composition of explanations for the acceptance or rejection of such amendments.

In what follows, I would first like to sketch out in greater detail Congar's activity in each of these phases to the extent that it has some bearing upon the evolution of *Lumen gentium*. Then I will point out, to the extent that this is possible, the traces of his influence upon that Dogmatic Constitution on the Church as well as his overall estimation of the ecclesiological doctrine of Vatican II.

*The Preparatory Phase (July 1960 – October 11, 1962)*¹²

Insofar as it entailed participation in the work of the preparatory commission, this phase was largely a time of frustration for Congar. On four occasions he attended meetings of the commission in Rome (November 13-17, 1960; September 17-29, 1961; November 20-23, 1961 and March 4-10, 1962), but felt that he and other participants like de Lubac, Häring and Delhay were given no effective voice, the work being dominated by those who lived in Rome, especially by those connected with the Holy Office.¹³ He submitted several *vota* at the request of the commission – *De episcopis*; *De laicis* and *De oecumenismo* – but none of them seemed to have had much of an impact on the drafts that were produced.¹⁴ In early November of 1962, as many criticisms were being voiced by the council fathers and *periti* concerning these drafts, Congar writes a kind of *mea culpa* in his journal, offe-

¹² For further information about this phase, see É. FOUILLLOUX, «Comment», 307-320; AL. MELLONI, «Yves Congar à Vatican II», 121-124; ID., «Introduction», XXX-XXXIII; and J. WICKS, «Yves Congar's Doctrinal Service», 516-520.

¹³ Congar's notes about these meetings can be found in *Mon journal*, I, 25-44, 60-79, 80-85 and 86-98, respectively.

¹⁴ Cf. *Mon journal*, I, 181-182. It should be added, however, that his remarks about the preparatory drafts are not all negative. Concerning chapter VI of the *De ecclesia* produced by the preparatory commission, he wrote: «Il y a de bonnes choses. Le chap. *De laicis* rejoint assez exactement mes idées et mon propre papier. Il a été rédigé par Mgr Philips» (*Mon journal*, I, 57). Later in the journal, on page 233, Congar identifies his 'notes' written for the preparatory commission in a slightly different way: *De episcopis*, *De modo exprimendi habitudinem non catholicorum ad ecclesiam* and *De oecumenismo*. Obviously in this second list his *De laicis* does not appear.

ring five reasons to explain why he and others of the commission were unable to be more critical in the months prior to the council so as to come up with more satisfactory texts.¹⁵ Perhaps the most important reason given was the change from what he called the «climate of the 'Holy Office' and of the chairs at the Roman colleges», which stifled new thinking and preferred simply to draw up documents which synthesized the teachings of the popes from Pius IX to Pius XII, to a new pastoral climate of freedom, dialogue and openness, which was produced by the gathering of the bishops throughout the world.¹⁶ Basically, his critique of the prepared drafts, voiced already many months prior to the opening of the council, was that they were too scholastic, not ecumenical and, especially, not rooted in scripture and tradition. To the extent that they borrowed mainly from papal teaching of the previous century, they tragically took as their source the Church and not the Word of God.¹⁷

While what was described in the previous paragraph was taking place within the preparatory commission in Rome, there was another very important avenue by which Congar could contribute to the preparation of the council in the period between its announcement by John XXIII on January 25, 1959, and its opening session on October 11, 1962. This was the area of his work as a theologian. Already on February 15, 1959 – thus less than three weeks after Pope John's announcement – an article appeared in *Informations catholiques internationales* which expressed the hope that the coming council would not propose a definition of some new Marian dogma, as in fact many of the suggestions which were sent to Rome in the subsequent months would request, but rather that it would seek to complete the unfinished work of Vatican I by balancing that council's doctrine of papal primacy with a presentation of the ministry of bishops, with a presentation of horizontal catholicity among local churches, with a solicitude for the world and for ecumenism.¹⁸ Later that year, at the abbey of

¹⁵ Cf. *Mon journal*, I, 181-182.

¹⁶ On the desire by the Roman members of the preparatory theological commission to present simply a synthesis of papal teaching, Congar writes, on August 24, 1961: «C'est un résumé des documents pontificaux depuis un siècle: un sorte de *syllabus* de ces documents, y inclus le discours de Pie XII» (*Mon journal*, I, 57).

¹⁷ «C'est très peu biblique (sauf le *De laicis* et quelques morceaux du *De ordine Morali*). L'écriture ne vient guère qu'en citation ornementale [...]. La source, c'est l'Église. Je vois là l'aboutissement tragique du mouvement dont j'ai dessiné l'histoire dans ma *Tradition*. [...] D'un côté, les papes proclament que la source et la règle de tout est l'Écriture et la Tradition, et qu'ils ne font, eux, que la garder et l'interpréter. Mais, d'un autre côté, ils agissent, et il veulent qu'on agisse – et ils font tout, avec une puissance implacable, pour qu'on agisse – comme si eux-mêmes étaient la source» (*Mon journal*, I, 59).

¹⁸ So É. FOUILLOUX, «Comment», 313. While this article was unsigned, Congar accepts credit for it in *Mon journal*, I, 3.

Chevetogne, Congar participated in a symposium on ecumenical councils, which had been organized as a contribution to the preparation for the newly announced council. There he gave a paper about the primacy of the first four councils and his conclusion to the volume which issued from the symposium called for the upcoming council to treat of episcopal collegiality and the relation between scripture and tradition.¹⁹ In a conference delivered during the annual octave of prayer for Christian Unity in January of 1960, Congar pointed out the need to rebalance Catholic ecclesiology, which had become too focused upon the central authority exercised by Rome. He expressed the hope that a more pastoral tone might be adopted by the magisterium and called for the establishment of some Vatican office which would be devoted to ecumenism and would facilitate the presence of non-Catholic Christians at the council.²⁰ Congar himself was convinced that another publication which he edited and to which he contributed on the eve of the council – *L'Épiscopat et l'Église universelle* – played a considerable role in helping the bishops to understand collegiality and eventually to vote for its inclusion in the Constitution on the Church. That success led him to set up a team of theologians to produce a volume entitled *Église et pauvreté* in the hope of having a similar influence regarding this theme.²¹

In addition to these writings which were occasioned by the announcement of the council, one should also point out that many of the themes treated in the publications of Congar during the decades prior to Vatican II became topics about which the council produced some of its most appreciated teaching. He himself acknowledged this when he wrote:

I was not to know – Another knew it on my behalf! – that this would pave the way for Vatican II. I was filled to overflowing. All the things to which I have given special attention issued in the Council: ecclesiology, ecumenism, reform of the Church, the lay state, mission, ministries, collegiality, return to the sources and Tradition.²²

Thus not only his publications from the very eve of Vatican II but perhaps even more those from the twenty-five years prior to the council turned out to have a significant influence upon the way in which many

¹⁹ Cf. «Conclusion» in: *Le Concile et les conciles. Contribution à l'histoire de la vie conciliaire de l'Église*, Paris, 1960, 285-334.

²⁰ So É. FOUILLOUX, «Comment», 313.

²¹ On Congar's view of the influence of *L'Épiscopat et l'Église universelle*, Paris, 1962, see *Mon journal*, I, 564, where on Nov. 22, 1963, he writes that, for the question of the episcopacy, «ce livre a été décisif». It contained his important essay «La hiérarchie comme service dû selon le Nouveau Testament et les documents de la Tradition», 67-100. Both on this page and later on Jan. 22, 1964, he writes of the project for a new collaborative publication on the Church and poverty; cf. *Mon journal*, II, 7. Concerning *L'Épiscopat* and other influential writings by Congar in the years prior to the council, see AL. MELLONI, «Yves Congar à Vatican II» 122-123.

²² Y. CONGAR, «Reflections on Being a Theologian» in *New Blackfriars* 62 (1981) 409.

bishops came to think about ecclesiological issues. This was very much in evidence at Vatican II. By the end of the third week of the first session, Congar could write in his diary: «I am confused by the extravagant credit which I am given from every side. They do not cease from approaching me even in St. Peter's. I hesitate even to say my name, since that unleashes protestations of affection and veneration».²³ This prestige was, ironically, even sometimes used to counter positions which Congar favored, such as when opponents of the proposed teaching on collegiality referred to his published call for further studies of the topic as evidence that it was still too much of an innovation to be taught by an ecumenical council.²⁴

In his brief concluding summary to the first volume of the history of the council, Giuseppe Alberigo cautions against a 'Manichean' evaluation of the preparatory period, as if it were all black or white.²⁵ After all, the draft for the constitution on the liturgy was of such high quality that it became the basis for the discussion of the bishops in 1962 and their first major document, *Sacrosanctum concilium*, in the following year. That being said, however, the criticism of *De ecclesia* and the other drafts which been produced by the preparatory commission lead Alberigo to write of a double preparation – the institutional preparation very much in the hands of people in Rome and characterized by a defensive spirit which lacked the imagination and excitement aroused by John XXIII's announcement of the council and that more informal preparation which was stirring in so many parts of the world and finding expression in many popular and scientific publications during the years 1959-1962. «It was especially this informal, diffused and spontaneous preparation which created the conditions allowing the

²³ Entry of October 31, 1962, in *Mon journal*, I, 177.

²⁴ See *Mon journal*, II, 163, 167 and 188. In fact, his *bloc-notes*, which appeared in *Informations catholiques internationales* during the sessions of the council and subsequently were gathered together with other of his pertinent essays and published as small books, do call for greater study of collegiality, though obviously not for the purpose of denying it but to promote its wider acceptance. For example, in the English translation of the volume covering the second session (1963), Congar writes concerning the collegiality of bishops and the connection between the authority of the bishop and his consecration: «Unfortunately, strange as it may appear, the necessary historical studies for a full appreciation of the theological tradition in these matters are completely lacking. Theology, for the past century especially, has been onesided in its expression. It must find again, or return to, many of the fundamental ideas that form its heritage» (Y. CONGAR, *Report from Rome II*, London, 1964, 33). In *Le Concile au jour le jour. Troisième session*, Paris, 1965, 13, he refers to *L'Épiscopat et l'Église universelle*, cited above in note 21, as well as to J. LÉCUYER, *Études sur la collégialité épiscopale*, Lyon, 1964, and to G. ALBERIGO, *Lo sviluppo della dottrina sui poteri nella Chiesa universale*, Roma, 1964, as providing some of the needed research, yet continues to affirm that more historical, theological and canonical studies relevant to the collegial structure of pastoral power in the Church are needed.

²⁵ «Preparazione per quale concilio?» in G. ALBERIGO (dir.), *Storia del concilio Vaticano II*, Vol. I: *Il cattolicesimo verso una nuova stagione; L'annuncio e la preparazione gennaio 1959 – settembre 1962*, Bologna, 1995, 522.

council to be an effective, innovative event», wrote Alberigo.²⁶ Congar was keenly aware of the importance of solid and tireless work for bringing about what he hoped would be the positive results of the council. Thus, after his frustrations during the preparatory period, on the very opening day of the council, he wrote in his journal of two great desires: to be and act as a *homo plene evangelicus* and to work. Regarding the latter, he had great confidence that hard work would demonstrate the truth of the tradition which could lead to a renewal of the Church and that the more he was able to produce theological and historical studies of high quality and to place these in a popular form accessible to the wider Catholic public the more effective would be his service to this renewal.

*The First Period (Oct. 11 – Dec. 8, 1962)*²⁷

Congar attached great importance to the fact that an ecumenical council is a collegial act by the bishops of the whole catholic communion who are gathered to deliberate collectively on issues of faith which concern the life of the Church.²⁸ The role of theologians during a council is to offer assistance to the bishops in this great collegial act of deliberation. He wrote that as a practical rule, he decided to do nothing except at the request of the bishops: «c'est EUX qui sont le concile».²⁹ At the same time, he was struck by the fact that the role of theologians at Vatican II was so much greater than their role during the First Vatican Council.³⁰

²⁶ *Ibid.*, 523.

²⁷ On this period, see also É. FOUILLOUX, «Comment», 320-331; AL. MELLONI, «Yves Congar à Vatican II», 124-129; É. MAHIEU, «Introduction», XXXIII-XXXVI; and J. WICKS, «Yves Congar's Doctrinal Service», 520-525.

²⁸ For this reason, the very holding of Vatican II was a tremendous support for one of the key doctrines which the council was to elaborate with such care and effort – the doctrine of collegiality. See Y. CONGAR, «Le fait et l'expérience conciliaires» in *Id.*, *Le concile au jour le jour. Quatrième session*, Paris, 1966, 121-126, and Y. CONGAR, «La théologie au concile» in *Id.*, *Situations et tâches présentes de théologie*, Paris, 1967, 49. Congar frequently quoted the dictum of the Council of Chalcedon – *Concilium episcoporum est* – and placed the role of theologians within the context of assisting the bishops. See, for example, «Le fait et l'expérience conciliaires», 123; *Id.*, «La théologie au concile», 47, and *Id.*, «Regard sur le concile Vatican II» in *Id.*, *Le concile de Vatican II*, Paris, 1984, 53.

²⁹ Oct. 31, 1962, in *Mon journal*, I, 177.

³⁰ «Je suis aussi frappé, depuis plusieurs jours, du rôle que jouent les théologiens. Au premier concile du Vatican, ils n'ont guère joué de rôle. [...] Cette fois, les évêques sont beaucoup plus pasteurs. Ils sont moins théologiens. D'autre part, il existe dans l'Église un large groupe de théologiens vivants et qui ne se cantonnent pas dans les chapitres tout faits de la théologie d'école, mais s'efforcent de penser et d'éclairer les faits de la vie de l'Église. Ces théologiens sont assez nombreux. Ils sont très loin d'être tous à Rome, mais rien qu'ici je vois: Chenu, Colson, Chavasse, Ratzinger, Rahner, Semmelroth, Lubac, Rondet, Daniélou, Schillebeeckx, etc., etc. Ces théologiens exercent un véritable magistère. Ce que Pie IX avait voulu éviter, au risque de braquer Döllinger, c'est là» (Oct. 21, 1962 in *Mon journal*, I, 137).

Éric Mahieu's fine introduction to Congar's council diaries includes a sub-section entitled «Les différents modes d'action du P. Congar au Concile», which divides that activity into four categories: his work with other theologians both within and outside the various commissions, his availability to bishops to provide lectures and help on interventions and *modi*, his contacts with the observers from other Christian communities and his continuing publications during the council.³¹ In terms of Congar's influence on the production of *Lumen gentium*, a word should be added here about two of these: his collaboration with theologians and his assistance to bishops.

Congar was impressed by the energy and critical spirit which was brought to the council by the theologians coming from France, Germany and, especially, Belgium. During the first session, his collaboration with other theologians was at an unofficial level, since at that time he still served only as personal advisor to the Archbishop of Strasbourg and was not working on any conciliar commissions. One instance of such unofficial collaboration is particularly surprising because it took place already on October 19, 1962 – only eight days after the beginning of the council! – and may be emblematic of the theological interchange and struggle which would mark much of the four sessions. Bishop Hermann Volk of Mainz organized a meeting to which he invited various Council fathers and *periti* whom he believed had deep concerns about the adequacy of some of the prepared drafts, especially that entitled *De fontibus*. In addition to Bishop Volk the group included bishops Reuss, Bengsch, Elchinger, Weber, Schmitt, Garrone, Guerry and Ancel and theologians Rahner, de Lubac, Daniélou, Grillmeier, Semmelroth, Rondet, Labourdette, Congar, Chenu, Schillebeeckx, Feiner, Ratzinger, Philips, Fransen and Küng.³² The Germans, Congar noted, wanted simply to oppose the prepared drafts and to begin writing new texts – in fact, the meeting assigned Congar and several others to draft a short kerygmatic text about salvation history, to which he devoted much of his free time until the end of October.³³ The Belgians and the

³¹ Cf. *Mon journal*, I, XLVII-L.

³² A sketch of the activities of this group during the first session is given in Y. Congar, «Erinnerungen an eine Episode auf dem II. Vatikanischen Konzil» in E. KLINGER and K. WITTSTADT (eds.), *Glaube im Prozess*, Freiburg-Basel-Wien, 1984, 22-32. Also cf. *Mon journal*, I, 122-124.

³³ References to this text which Congar calls a *Proemium* can be found in *Mon journal*, I, 123-124, 142-143, 152-153 and 156, the last page indicating that he turned in his text to the small drafting group convoked by Bishop Volk on Sunday, October 28, 1962. The text was further revised by Congar on Nov. 6th; cf. *Mon journal*, I, 187. On Nov. 4, Daniélou had suggested that it be used as the beginning of a dogmatic constitution on anthropology, addressing the themes of *imago Dei* and original sin; *Mon journal*, I, 181. In fact, some passages from this *Proemium* eventually appeared in Daniélou's draft for Chapter I of Schema XVII, which eventually was included in the anthropological doctrine in Part I of *Gaudium et spes*; see *Mon journal*, I, 368, note 5.

French, on the other hand, argued against the wholesale rejection of earlier drafts, thinking that such a tactic would scarcely create the climate needed for creating consensus around more satisfactory texts. This more conciliatory approach can be seen already in the beginnings of an alternative *De ecclesia* produced by Msgr. Gerard Philips during November of 1962.³⁴ This meeting and its aftermath illustrate a recurrent theme running throughout Congar's diaries of the council, that is, the importance of providing an effective strategy in order to gain the best chances of coming up with a good text which could be acceptable to bishops from such different backgrounds and theological points of view. In this first session of the council, Congar attended several further meetings of small groups of theologians to consider drafts of what would become the 'schema Philips', the basis for the eventual constitution *Lumen gentium*.³⁵

Congar's contributions during the first period of the council also included his many informal exchanges with bishops, first of all, simply through conversations during the afternoons and at meals.³⁶ In addition, he frequently was requested to give lectures on themes to be taken up by the council and once even was asked to provide bibliography for the bishops to study.³⁷ Often he addressed the theme of Tradition, which was, at the time, the topic of some of his most recent publications, as well as one of the major

³⁴ Two versions of the *Schema Philips* are printed in Fr.G. HELLIN, *Concilii Vaticani II Synopsis* [...] *Constitutio Dogmatica De Ecclesia Lumen Gentium*, Città del Vaticano, 1995, 694-715. In the introduction to the second of these versions, on page 706-707, one finds an effort to show how the new draft preserves the themes contained in the eleven chapters of the *De ecclesia* which had been drawn up by the preparatory theological commission. Congar often referred to the genius of Msgr. Philips as entailing precisely the ability to introduce changes to texts in a way that satisfied those calling for change, without thereby alienating those whose drafts were being altered.

³⁵ Cf. *Mon journal*, II, 562, which lists all of the principal meetings of theologians which Congar attended in the first three sessions concerning the production of *De ecclesia*. Two during the first session – on Oct. 25th and on Nov. 6th – considered new drafts prepared by Philips on *De episcopis* and *De ecclesia*.

³⁶ For this observation, as well as for much of the rest of this paragraph, I am following the fine summary of Congar's activity during the first session which has been compiled by É. FOUILLOUX, «Comment», 322-323.

³⁷ The bibliography request by the Brazilian bishops is mentioned in *Mon journal*, I, 136. Other requests during the first session came from African, Melkite, French, Latin American and Argentinian groups of bishops, along with requests from various ecclesiastical colleges in Rome – the La Salette, Belgian and North American Colleges, the Capranicum and the Angelicum. These latter conferences to students were sometimes attended by bishops as well, such as the one delivered at the Capranicum on Nov. 22, during which Congar was sharply criticized by Archbishop Raffaele Calabria of Benevento. References to the preparation and delivery of such conferences during the first session can be found in *Mon journal*, I, 132, 136, 153, 154, 180, 188, 193-194, 196, 205, 209, 216, 241, 254, 262, 280, 288, 302 and 308. É. FOUILLOUX, «Comment», 323, counts nine conferences for bishops: four on tradition, two on the council, in general, two promoting a more humble, less lordly exercise of episcopal office and one on ecumenism.

subjects treated in the *De fontibus* draft, debated during the general congregations from Nov. 14-21, 1962. When it was decided to withdraw that schema and to set up a mixed commission to consider a new approach to the topic, some bishops congratulated Congar as if it had been a personal victory for him.³⁸ Fouilloux counted twelve requests from individual bishops during the first session, asking Congar for help in drafting ideas for their comments during the debates in the conciliar aula, noting that five of such requests actually resulted in spoken or written interventions. Another service came in the form of opinions which Congar wrote for the series entitled *Études et documents*, published by the French bishops but reaching an audience of bishops much wider than that sole group.³⁹ Finally, there were several meetings with groups of French bishops during the first session (Nov. 26th and 28th and Dec. 1st) and at the beginning of the intersession (Jan. 24th and Feb. 6-7, 1963), to discuss the schema on Mary and the schema *De ecclesia*.⁴⁰

Thus, at the close of the first session, Congar would have had to feel happy about some developments: the conciliar spirit which immediately emerged among the bishops as expressed in their determination to deliberate actively and not simply to ratify what had been prepared beforehand, the presence and prominent place assigned to the observers from other Christian communities, the fruitful progress made toward a Constitution on the liturgy and the decisions to reconsider in a substantial way the texts on revelation, ecumenism and the Church. Wicks' calls the first session «a consoling time for Congar», especially because of the thanks he received from many Council participants for his writings and the requests of advice from many doctoral students about their theses.⁴¹ Nevertheless, his attitude at the close of the first session was not one of unguarded optimism. When he heard from Fr. Camelot about the events of the last meeting (Dec. 7, 1962) of the mixed commission which had been established to provide a new *De revelatione*, during which Bishop De Smedt protested against a recent letter of nineteen cardinals who wanted the council to warn against the dangers of biblical criticism, Congar could not suppress his bitter disappointment and hurt, which had surfaced within him again as he was returning the day

³⁸ Cf. *Mon journal*, I, 251; E. FOUILLOUX, «Comment», 307.

³⁹ Cf. É. MAHIEU, «Introduction», XLIX.

⁴⁰ See the chronology of Congar's work on *Lumen gentium* as printed in *Mon journal*, II, 562. This source also lists two other meetings of small groups of theologians and bishops in early 1963, one at Louvain and organized by G. Thils on Jan. 12th-13th and one at Mainz organized by Bishop Volk on January 25th-26th.

⁴¹ J. WICKS, «Yves Congar's Doctrinal Service», 520. Wicks adds, however, that Congar was disappointed that the French bishops did not employ their *periti* as effectively as did the episcopates from some of the other countries.

before by train from Naples as he recalled the suspicion directed long ago against his *Vraie et fausse réforme dans l'Église*, a suspicion that evidently still dominated the thinking of some powerful bishops and theologians.⁴² He was by no means sure that the council was the forum in which this negative spirit could be overcome and the pastoral, faith-nourishing texts, for which John XXIII had hoped when he convoked the council, could be achieved.

From the First Intersession until the Promulgation of Lumen gentium (March 1, 1963 – November 21, 1964)⁴³

Jan Grootaers has suggested that the first intersession (Dec. 9, 1962 to Sept. 29, 1963) could, with some justification, be called the second preparatory period of the council.⁴⁴ This was because, as we have seen, much of the work presented during the first session was not found to be acceptable to the Council Fathers. Regarding the *De ecclesia* draft, the bishops had been invited on the day before the closing of the first session to send in any further comments and suggestions by Feb. 28, 1963. It so happened that precisely on the following day, March 1st, Congar received in Strasbourg a special delivery letter from Jean Daniélou, inviting him to come immediately to Rome to take the latter's place among the *periti* working on the new text on the Church. Wicks calls this event a «breakthrough in Congar's conciliar activity».⁴⁵ His role shifted significantly in that now he began to work directly on drafts which eventually would become parts of fully eight of the sixteen council documents!

From early March until the beginning of the second session, Congar attended three meetings (March 1-14, May 15-28 and Sept. 7-8 and 17) which were held, first of all, in order to refashion the eleven chapters of the original *De ecclesia* into the four which had been proposed by Philips already in November of 1962, all the while integrating the comments that

⁴² *Mon journal*, I, 313-314.

⁴³ For more information on this phase, see AL. MELLONI, «Yves Congar à Vatican II», 130-150; É. MAHIEU, «Introduction», XXXVI-XLII; and J. WICKS, «Yves Congar's Doctrinal Service», 525-538.

⁴⁴ Thus the title of his chapter, «Il Concilio si gioca nell'intervallo. La 'seconda preparazione' e i suoi avversari» in G. ALBERIGO (a cura di), *Storia del concilio Vaticano II*, Vol. II, *La formazione della coscienza conciliare. Ottobre 1962-settembre 1963*, Bologna, 1996, 385-558. AL. MELLONI, «Yves Congar à Vatican II», 130, seconds that opinion.

⁴⁵ J. WICKS, «Yves Congar's Doctrinal Service», 525. According to É. FOUILLOUX, «Comment», 326 and 329-330, it was especially Charles Moeller and Bishop De Smedt who urged Archbishop Garrone to utilize Congar in the re-writing of *De ecclesia*. Pages 525-538 of Wicks' article give an extensive presentation of the time covered in the present subsection of our study (from March 1963 until November 21, 1964, the date of the promulgation of *Lumen gentium*), rich in detail about the work, insights and experiences of Congar at that time. Our presentation must be more limited here.

the Council Fathers had made during the debate in aula as the first session was coming to a close or had sent in afterwards. Two of these meetings also worked on Schema XVII, which eventually became *Gaudium et spes*, and on *De Oecumenismo*, which, because at that stage it included chapters on the Jewish people and on religious freedom that would eventually serve as the basis for separate documents, became the source for *Unitatis redintegratio*, *Nostra aetate* and *Dignitatis humanae*. It is important to keep in mind the fact that, at the same time Congar was working on the text that would become *Lumen gentium*, he was also engaged in drafting for several other council documents. On July 4, 1963, Cardinal Suenens suggested that some of the material from the first and third chapters of the new schema *De ecclesia* be put together to form a new second chapter entitled «The People of God».⁴⁶ In the meeting held at Malines on Sept. 7, 1963, Congar was one of those enlisted to work on this text and would continue to do so until it was finally adopted on the closing day of the third session (Nov. 21, 1964).

Almost half (Sept. 30 – Oct. 31) of the second session of Vatican II (Sept. 29-Dec. 4, 1963) was devoted to the discussion of the new *De ecclesia*, which had been drawn up in March and May of that year on the basis of the *schema Philips* but was also attentive to include what appeared in the other alternative schemas as well as what was to be preserved from the original *De ecclesia* of 1962.⁴⁷ It should be kept in mind that the text discussed in the aula was comprised of four chapters: I. *De ecclesiae mysterio*; II. *De constitutione hierarchica ecclesiae et in specie: de episcopatu*; III. *De populo Dei et speciatim de laicis*; and IV. *De vocatione ad sanctitatem in ecclesia*. The new Chapter II, as such, had not yet been written and distributed to the bishops when their principal debate of *De ecclesia* took place in October of 1963.

⁴⁶ *Acta Synodalia*, Vol. V: *Processus verbales*, Pars I, Città del Vaticano, 1989, 594 and 635. On the dating of this proposal, see the «Chronologia Constitutionis Dogmaticae *De Ecclesia*», printed in Fr.G. HELLIN, *Synopsis*, XXVI, at the entry 4.VII.1963. The actual proposal is printed in *Ibid.*, 868-871. Congar does not seem to be aware of this event, since his first references to this new chapter II on the people of God make no reference to Suenens or the proposal to the Coordinating Commission on that date; cf. *Mon journal*, I, 388 and 395. There was not enough time in the late summer of 1963 to draft this new chapter and to present it to the bishops during the second session. Suenens' suggestion would be accepted by the theological commission of the Council only during the second session, on October 9, 1963; see Y. CONGAR, «D'une 'ecclesiologie en gestation' à *Lumen Gentium* (Chap. I et II)» in *Le concile de Vatican II* 123-136 at 131. His account of part of the discussion and of the vote of the theological commission on that day is found in *Mon journal*, I, 449-450.

⁴⁷ The fact that this work entailed a tremendous effort at synthesis is reflected in the following comment found in the «Prefatory Note» at the beginning of Fr.G. HELLIN, *Synopsis*: «This new Schema, which incorporates much of the preceding one, is based on the draft presented by Msgr. Philips. The other four draft projects (which were the work respectively of Father [sic; it should be 'His Excellency'] P. Parente and of the German, Chilean and French bishops) were also taken into consideration» (XXII).

Because of this, Congar could make the rather astounding observation that the evolution of the final text of *Lumen gentium* was «such that the idea and over-all structure of the chapter on the People of God were never really discussed at the Council».⁴⁸ Of course, the bishops did have the opportunity to voice their views concerning the overall structure of this chapter through the votation process which approved it in the following session, on Sept. 17-18, 1964, and in their votes on the *modi* to Chapter II of *Lumen gentium* on Oct. 30th of the same year. In addition, one should not forget that the discussion in October of 1963 actually did cover much of the material which would appear in the new chapter on the People of God, though at the time it was to be found in the chapter dedicated to the laity, just as the material which eventually became Chapters V and VI of *Lumen gentium* was still bound together as the then Chapter IV on the vocation to holiness in the Church. Indeed, it was precisely the discussion of October 1963 which caused the four chapters then considered by the bishops to evolve into six.

Two votes also occurred in October of 1963 which would have an important impact upon *Lumen gentium*. First was the vote of October 29, concerning whether to include the council's teaching about Mary, the Mother of Jesus, within the Constitution on the Church. Before the vote, the moderators felt it necessary to counter the impression that including Mary in the text on the Church would somehow diminish what the council wished to teach about her; it was only a question of where to place that teaching – within the document on the Church or in a separate text. The result was perhaps the closest vote of the entire council: of 2,193 votes, 1,114 favored inclusion while 1,074 opposed, with five null votes.⁴⁹ This decision turned out to have an even greater significance for the ultimate structure of *Lumen gentium*, since it soon became clear that not one but two additional chapters would be needed. A final chapter on Mary as model, guide and expression of the final state of the Church would need to be preceded by a penultimate chapter on the pilgrim Church's journey toward its eschatological fulfillment.⁵⁰ Thus, the council at last reached the structure of eight chapters which make up the final form of the Constitution on the Church. The second vote having a profound effect on the ultimate doctrine of

⁴⁸ Y. Congar, «The People of God» in J.H. MILLER (ed.), *Vatican II: An Interfaith Appraisal*, Notre Dame, 1966, 197.

⁴⁹ Congar would write: «C'est une bien petite majorité: il restera un malaise [...]. Mais c'est décidé» (*Mon journal*, I, 508).

⁵⁰ One of the last doctoral dissertations written at the Gregorian University under the guidance of Prof. Angel Antón, of recent and fond memory, was I. GAZTELU PASTOR, *Communio sanctorum. La presencia del tema de la comunio [consortium] en el capítulo VII de Lumen gentium al la luz del Iter general de la constitución*, Roma, 2003; it shows the relation between the addition of Chapter VII and the vote to include the chapter on Mary as the final chapter of the Constitution on the Church. On this relation, see also *Mon journal*, II, 33.

Lumen gentium occurred the following day, on October 30, and concerned the sacramentality of episcopal consecration, collegiality and the restoration of the permanent diaconate. These were all important issues that needed to be taken into account in the redrafting of what would now become Chapter III of *Lumen gentium*, «The Hierarchical Constitution of the Church and, especially, the episcopate.» While Congar's publications were very influential in setting forth the basis in Tradition for these teachings about the nature and exercise of the episcopal office, especially its collegial exercise, the fact that he was assigned to work on the new chapter on the People of God meant that he was excluded from drafting those passages which were to be so hotly contested in the third session, when the struggle over collegiality would flare up once again.⁵¹

Following the discussion of *De ecclesia* from Sept. 30-Oct. 31, 1963, Congar worked for the rest of the second session with other members of the sub-committee charged with drafting the new chapter on the People of God. This work would continue at various meetings during the second intersession (Jan. 30-Feb. 1, March 2-13 and June 1-8, all of 1964). In addition, he was assigned to the sub-committee charged with writing the new Chapter VII, «On the Eschatological Nature of the Pilgrim Church and her Union with the Heavenly Church».⁵² All of this had to take into account the *modi* which had now been suggested by the various council Fathers during the previous sessions. In his journal for the third of June, 1964, Congar recounts a conversation with Pierre Duprey of the Secretariat for the Promotion of Christian Unity, who expressed concerns that some of the texts in the current draft of the Constitution on the Church would create difficulties for the Orthodox.⁵³ This worry may be related to the thirteen alterations suggested by Pope Paul VI several days earlier (on May 19th), which tended to strengthen the texts affirming the authority of the head of the college, apparently in order to respond to those bishops who feared that the doctrine of collegiality was not fully in harmony with Vatican I's teaching about papal primacy.⁵⁴ At the beginning of August, 1964, Congar spent his

⁵¹ His assignment to collaborate on the writing of Chapter II of *Lumen gentium* is listed in *Acta Synodalia Sacrosancti Concilii Oecumenici Vaticani Secundi*, Volumen III, Pars I, Città del Vaticano, 1973, 208. AL. MELLONI, «Yves Congar à Vatican II», 136 and 145, also notes that this drafting assignment made Congar more a 'spectator' than a protagonist in the main debate which raged during the discussion of *Lumen gentium*, that is, the debate over collegiality. Still, as noted above, Congar himself was convinced that solid theological work was the most powerful force in bringing about change. Thus, his influence in the collegiality debate should not be limited to his sub-committee assignment.

⁵² See *Acta Synodalia Sacrosancti Concilii Oecumenici Vaticani Secundi*, Volumen III, Pars I, 351.

⁵³ Cf. *Mon journal*, II, 94-97.

'vacation' with his confreres Frs. Dupuy and Feret writing potential interventions and amendments to offer to bishops who might be willing to try to nuance Chapter III of *Lumen gentium* in such a way as to make it more appealing to the Orthodox.⁵⁵

The third session (Sept. 14 – Nov. 21, 1964) opened with the relatively short discussion of the newly prepared Chapters VII and VIII of *Lumen gentium* (Sept. 15th-18th) along with votes on all of previously discussed chapters and the amendments made to each of them. It was crushing work, especially when one remembers that Congar was also working on the drafting or improvement of other council documents at the same time. Perhaps most important to note here regarding the Constitution on the Church is the fact that the third session was characterized by a last ditch effort on the part of some bishops to have the doctrine of collegiality removed from the text. Congar refers to these bishops and *periti* as «les anticollégiaux» several times in his diary and writes of collegiality as still being under attack, only several days before the final vote accepting *Lumen gentium*.⁵⁶ When the *Nota explicativa praevia* was added as an interpretative key for Chapter III, some bishops and *periti* believed that it might render void what had been earlier affirmed concerning collegiality. Indeed, Congar notes that those who were against collegiality thought that they had won the day. But he advised caution, encouraging bishops not to take issue with the *Nota explicativa praevia* and instead simply to vote in favor of the chapter as to be understood in light of it. In his view, not only did the explanatory note not

⁵⁴ That Congar himself felt that Paul VI's 13 changes did not damage the doctrine of collegiality, see *Mon journal*, II, 100-102, 106-107, 272. His reaction, in contrast to some of the other theologians and bishops, was the same regarding the *Nota explicativa praevia*; cf. *Ibid.*, 248, 253-254.

⁵⁵ He describes this work briefly in *Mon journal*, II, 120. Congar writes about his hopes for these *modi* very often in the entries which appear at the beginning of the third session of the council and of his disappointment to see that those he succeeded in having submitted by various bishops were mostly rejected because of the strict rules adopted for the acceptance of amendments. Congar understood that such rules were a means by which Msgr. Philips was able to reject many amendments which were contrary to collegiality. At the same time, Congar lamented that such rules also prevented a true improvement of the text, which could have made it more ecumenical. On the criteria for accepting or rejecting *modi*, cf. *Mon journal*, II, 187; on the fact that nearly all of the *modi* prepared by Congar and his colleagues were rejected, cf. *Mon journal*, II, 230. A convincing interpretation of these amendments as an attempt to include an explicit recognition of the episcopate in the Orthodox Churches is offered by J. Wicks, «Yves Congar's Doctrinal Service», 537, who concludes that Congar and others had to be satisfied with the *Nota bene* at the end of the *Nota explicativa praevia*, «which left it to theological discussion whether Orthodox bishops not in communion with the See of Rome do have jurisdiction and a magisterium in their Churches». Congar's disappointment with this outcome is registered in *Mon journal*, II, 269. He even wrote on Nov. 14th: «Je crains que notre *De Ecclesia* ne crée un nouvel obstacle sur la voie du rapprochement» (*Mon journal*, II, 267).

⁵⁶ Cf. *Mon journal*, II, 227, 236, 259-260.

contradict the doctrine of collegiality, but he himself had argued that some explanation of terms was needed to prevent opponents of collegiality from giving an anti-primatial interpretation to the texts, an interpretation which was never intended.⁵⁷ Perhaps this might be seen as the last contribution of Congar to the process of producing *Lumen gentium*, that is, serving as a voice for calm and level-headedness at a moment when it seemed that the situation might get out of hand.

Traces of Congar's Influence upon Lumen gentium

On the day before the close of Vatican II, Congar reflected about his own role in the council, thanking God for 'filling' him so that he could contribute much more than would have been possible on the basis of his own «rigoureusement inexistants» merits. He also adds an invaluable comment concerning the precise texts upon which he worked: «These are by me: *Lumen gentium*, the first draft and various numbers of chap. I and numbers 9, 13, 16, 17 of chap. II, plus a few other particular passages».⁵⁸ What more can be added about these texts?

Lumen gentium, Chapter I. When comparing Chapter I of the schema drafted by Msgr. Philips during the first session of the council with the first chapter of the new draft which the Council Fathers discussed during the second session, it appears that the passages concerning the People of God, the Body of Christ and various biblical images for the Church have received greatest attention. This would also correspond with a comment by Congar from March 10, 1963, several days after he began to work on *De ecclesia*, in which he notes that Msgr. Philips had accepted his redaction of the chapter on the mystical body and on the images of the Church.⁵⁹ The following day H. Schrauf objected that the draft did not express the essential content of Pius XII's *Mystici corporis*, but Philips defended the text. Congar's diary admits that the new draft was less interested in following the teaching of the encyclical but rather sought to express the anthropological and soteriological themes found in the teaching of St. Paul. Another change appears in the addition of the following sentence: «Haec congregatio iustorum a Sanctis

⁵⁷ *Mon journal*, II, 269-274, is rich with passages about these turbulent days.

⁵⁸ *Mon journal*, II, 510-511. This passage goes on to add that he also worked on Chap. II of *De revelatione* and wrote the first draft of its paragraph 21; on all of *De oecumenismo*, with the *proemium* and conclusion being mainly his; the same for the Declaration on Non-Christian religions; Chapters I and IV of Schema XIII [of Part I]; Chapter I of *De missionibus* «is mine A to Z, with touches by Ratzinger on paragraph 8»; cooperation on the whole of *De libertate religiosa*, especially the theological parts, with the *proemium* being «of my hand»; three-fourths of *De presbyteris* was first drafted by Lécuyer-Onclin-Congar, with Congar contributing much to the re-writing of the introduction, numbers 2-9, 12-14 and the conclusion.

⁵⁹ Cf. *Mon journal*, I, 346.

Patribus Ecclesia universalis vocatur, 'quae ab Abel iusto usque ad ultimum electum' colligitur». This addition is followed by a long footnote giving credit for the quoted words to Gregory the Great, and adding confirming texts from Irenaeus, Origen, Augustine, Leo the Great, John Damascene and Thomas Aquinas, concluding with a reference to Congar's essay of 1952 on this theme.⁶⁰ Congar believed that identifying the universal Church as extending «from the just man Abel to the last of the elect» more firmly pointed to the historicity of the Church and to its relation to all of God's saving actions throughout history, including those with the people of Israel and even beyond. God's saving deeds should not simply be identified with the history of the Christian community.⁶¹ As these comments show, Congar's impact on Chapter I of *Lumen gentium* was to render it more biblical and patristic, strengthening its reflection of the historicity of the Church and of the Church's relation to those who are not Christians.

What about a theme which has been of great interest to commentators in the aftermath of Vatican II – the teaching in paragraph 8 that the Church of Christ «subsists in» the Catholic Church, guided by the successor of Peter and the bishops in communion with him? The draft which Congar inherited from Philips in early 1963 already acknowledged that many elements of sanctification could be found outside the boundaries of the Catholic Church, though it still used the verb «is» instead of «subsists in» to describe how the Catholic Church relates to the Church of Christ. The word «elements» was added by Philips to his first chapter in the early days of February, 1963, although even in its earlier stage it acknowledged that the Catholic Church knew itself to be united with other baptized Christians «for many reasons» (*plures ob rationes*).⁶² When one compares these texts with this precise point of the earlier *De ecclesia* of 1962, which has no mention of elements of sanctification outside the Catholic Church, one might jump to the conclusion that that earlier draft was totally lacking in this recognition

⁶⁰ Both the draft and this extensive footnote can be found in *Acta Synodalia Sacrosancti Concilii Oecumenici Vaticani Secundi*, Vol. II, Pars I, Città del Vaticano, 1971, 222, as well as in Fr.G. HELLÍN, *Synopsis*, 10. The article cited is «Ecclesia ab Abel», from M. REDING (ed.), *Abhandlungen über Theologie und Kirche. Festschrift für Karl Adam*, Düsseldorf, 1952, 79-108. Congar wrote that in a plenary meeting of the council's theological commission on Nov. 25, 1963, a great discussion broke out over the «ab Abel iusto» text, adding, after it was finally accepted: «Ensuite, on progresse, d'accrochage en accrochage, de phrase en phrase» (*Mon journal*, I, 573).

⁶¹ See Congar's comments in «The People of God» in H. MILLER (ed.), *Vatican II*, 201.

⁶² Compare the texts of November 1962 in Fr.G. HELLÍN, *Synopsis*, 708 (with the «est» sentence) and 709 («plures ob rationes»), with the February 1963 text in *Ibid.*, 679 (with «est» and «elementa quaedam sanctificationis») and, finally, with the text given to the bishops for the discussion in October 1963 during the second session, in *Ibid.*, 64 (with «est» and «elementa plura sanctificationis»).

of the ecclesial elements of other Christian communities. But that conclusion would be wrong. As is well known, the original *De ecclesia* of 1962 had eleven chapters, the last of which was dedicated to the theme of ecumenism. It reserved anything that it intended to say about other Christians and their communities to that final chapter, which was comprised of eight paragraphs (48-55), one of which (51 *De habitudine Ecclesiae Catholicae ad communitates christianas separatas*) explicitly acknowledges that certain elements of the Church exist in these other communities («In iis enim elementa quaedam Ecclesiae exsistunt»). To this passage is added a long footnote, listing many quotations from ecumenical councils and popes which use the word «ecclesia» for Eastern Churches not in full communion with the Bishop of Rome and ending with a reference to *Chrétiens désunis* of 1937, thus to a book published by none other than Congar himself some twenty-five years earlier!⁶³

Thus, even in that first *De ecclesia* draft, there was some recognition of ecclesial elements outside the Catholic Church, though unfortunately that recognition came only ten chapters after identifying Christ's Church with the Catholic Church and affirming, against the tradition as shown by the footnote to *Chrétiens désunis*, that only it had the right to be called «church».⁶⁴ It is revealing that the pages cited from that book are from its final appendix, which lists ways in which recent official Catholic documents had referred to other Christians. That was the kind of evidence, especially quotations from papal writings, which carried most weight within the preparatory theological commission. Unfortunately, no reference was made to the remarkable Chapter Seven of *Chrétiens désunis*, where Congar prophetically explores the relation of non-Catholic Christians and their communities to the one, unique Church of Christ. Regarding such communities, Congar uses the precise term «elements of Church» to describe the way in which they relate, in varying degrees, to the one Church of Christ.⁶⁵ Now the presence of these «ecclesial elements» provides the key for understanding the change from the verb «est» to «subsistit in» at Vatican II. Yet, remarkably, Congar seems to have made no reference to this change in his private diary. How can this be explained?

Recently a valuable historical discovery was made by the doctoral thesis of Alexandra von Teuffenbach regarding the surprising source as well as the precise date of the insertion of the expression «subsistit in» into *Lumen gentium* 8.⁶⁶ By careful analysis of notes in the personal archives of mem-

⁶³ See Fr.G. HELLÍN, *Synopsis*, 652-653.

⁶⁴ This text suffered from the problem of compartmentalization («compartimentage»), which Congar considered one of the major flaws of the thinking that went on in the preparatory theological commission; cf. *Mon journal*, I, 58.

⁶⁵ See Y. CONGAR, *Chrétiens désunis*, Paris, 1937, 277-308 and especially 300-307.

⁶⁶ A. VON TEUFFENBACH, *Die Bedeutung des Subsistit in (LG 8). Zum Selbstverständnis der Katholischen Kirche*, Roma, 2002.

bers of the theological commission along with three accounts of the meeting in question, von Teuffenbach demonstrated that the adoption of the verb «subsistit in» took place on the late afternoon of Tuesday, Nov. 26, 1963, as the plenary theological commission considered earlier changes that had been made to *Lumen gentium* 8 by a sub-committee working during the previous weeks of that month. Congar was not part of that sub-committee, but rather of a different one revising Chapter II of *Lumen gentium*. Therefore, the afternoon of the 26th would have been his only opportunity to hear of this change. Von Teuffenbach shows that sometime that November, the word «est» in paragraph 8 had been changed by the sub-committee to «adest». On the 26th, when the plenary theological commission first heard of this change, H. Schrauf immediately opposed it as being too weak to express the relation between the Church of Christ and the Catholic Church. When he suggested changing it back to the verb «est», S. Tromp offered «subsistit in» as an alternative. The discussion immediately jumped to another issue, and several minutes later G. Philips asked whether the commission wanted «subsistit in»; it was adopted without further comment.⁶⁷ Why does Congar make no mention of this in his diary?

As it so happened, the evening before (Nov. 25th), Congar had telephoned his home in Sedan, only to learn that his mother would probably not survive the night. At 22:40 he received a call informing him that she had died. He wrote the next morning of a «mystical history» of the council in which he believed that his mother would hold a great place, because, he knew, she had offered her sufferings and many prayers during the last years of her illness for its success and for the success of her son's efforts.⁶⁸ Congar left at noon on Nov. 26th to return home for his mother's funeral; thus was not present when the change to «subsistit in» was made. By the time he returned to Rome the following Saturday, after the experience of such a personal loss, he seems not to have noticed that the change had taken place.⁶⁹

Lumen gentium, Chapter II. This is the chapter for which Congar takes most credit in his diary entry of Dec. 7, 1965, specifying that he was responsible for four of its nine paragraphs: numbers 9, 13, 16 and 17. A first question which immediately comes to mind is the following: if the entire chapter was to some extent new, having been proposed by Cardinal Suenens

⁶⁷ The history I have just summarized can be found in *Ibid.*, 375-388.

⁶⁸ Cf. *Mon journal*, I, 573.

⁶⁹ In a rather ironic anecdote, given what we now know about the origin of the change to «subsistit in» and the reasons behind it, Congar recalled to Jean Puyo that in one meeting of the preliminary commission Fr. Tromp pounded his fist on the table, insisting that it had already been decided that the Body of Christ is identified with the Catholic Church and that Protestants or Orthodox did not participate in it. Congar added: it was so much decided that the council taught the opposite (cf. J. PUYO, *Une vie pour la vérité*, Paris, 1975, 126-127).

only in the summer of 1963 and thus after Congar had already begun to work on the *De ecclesia* subcommittee, why would he mention only these four paragraphs as primarily his responsibility? The answer lies in the fact that the remaining five paragraphs were taken over from earlier drafts. Even though they were significantly reworked, paragraphs 10-12 and 14-15 all derive from the first *De ecclesia*, prepared by the preparatory commission before the opening of the Council and discussed in early December, 1962. This reflects the determination of those like Philips and Congar who were convinced that the most effective way to make progress toward a document which would enjoy wide support was to maintain some level of continuity with the drafts of the preparatory commission, a fact that should dispel the false notion that the final version of *Lumen gentium* was a complete rejection of what that commission had prepared. In fact, even paragraph 16, for which Congar claims credit, also seems to have had an earlier form in Philips' two schemas, though the later version is sufficiently different to justify Congar's claim.⁷⁰ To grasp the contribution which these paragraphs make, it seems useful first to offer a brief summary of their content and then to present Congar's account of their origin and significance.

In the penultimate draft of *Lumen gentium*, each numbered paragraph was given a title within brackets as an aid to capture its central theme. Paragraph 9 bore the title «New Covenant and New People»⁷¹ unfolding the wide panorama which encompasses all of God's saving activity throughout history; it relates the new covenant established in Christ to the earlier covenant with Israel. Congar was pleased that the expression «messianic people», which he had introduced into the text, was accepted by the Council Fathers, though he was disappointed that it was not taken up later in *Gaudium et spes*.⁷² As messianic, even if only a small flock, this people is the seed of unity, hope and salvation for the whole world. It is a communion of

⁷⁰ The presence of these earlier drafts for paragraphs 10-12 and 14-16 can be verified by looking at the synopsis for Chapter II of *Lumen gentium* in Fr.G. HELLÍN, *Synopsis*, 71-143, especially 82-101 on paragraphs 10-12 and 110-137 on paragraphs 14-16. For paragraph 16, see also *Ibid.*, 698 and 710, for the precedents in Philips' schemas of February 1963 and of November 1962, respectively. It is somewhat easier to identify Gil Hellín's indications of prior texts, if one has at hand the «Conspectus schematum», printed in G. ALBERIGO, *Constitutionis dogmaticae Lumen Gentium synopsis historica*, Bologna, 1975, XXVIII-XXX.

⁷¹ These titles can be found in the Alberigo synopsis on page XXVIII and in the third column of the Gil Hellín synopsis at the beginning of each paragraph.

⁷² Cf. Y. CONGAR, «D'une 'Ecclésiologie en gestation' a *Lumen gentium* (Chap. I et II)» in ID., *Le concile de Vatican II. Son Église, Peuple de Dieu et Corps du Christ*, Paris, 1984, 135, who recalls that the expression «messianic people» was requested by Bishop Marty, under the inspiration of Chenu. Congar believed that this title could have provided a valuable nuance to understanding the Church's role in the world in the Constitution *Gaudium et spes*; see Y. CONGAR, «Part I, Chapter IV. The Role of the Church in the Modern World» in H. VORGRIMMER (ed.), *Commentary on the Documents of Vatican II*, Volume Five, New York, 1969, 215; see also Y. CONGAR, «The People of God» in J.H. MILLER (ed.), *Vatican II*, 206.

life, love and truth, an instrument of salvation. The Church advances through history, extending to all regions and races, and, though trials mark its journey, by grace it will not waver and will arrive at that light which knows no setting.

Paragraph 13 bears the subtitle «On the Universality or Catholicity of the One People of God» and affirms that all human beings are called to the one People of God, by the Son who was sent as teacher, priest and king, and through the Holy Spirit who gives life and is the principle of the Church's unity. This one people is comprised of persons from all nations; it does not denigrate the resources and cultures of the various peoples but takes all that is good and strengthens and elevates it. Catholicity means that each part of the Church contributes its gifts to the others. The Church is a communion of local Churches, each with their respective traditions. Legitimate diversity enriches unity and should be fostered by the ministry to unity of the successor to Peter. All human beings are called to this catholic unity and either belong or are related to it in differing ways: the Catholic faithful, others who believe in Christ and finally all humankind.

Paragraph 16 bears the subtitle «Concerning non-Christians» and affirms that those who have not yet received the Gospel are related to People of God in various ways. The special place of the People of Israel derives from the fact that «the gifts of God are without repentance» (cf. Rom 11,28-29), while Muslims are mentioned as «profess[ing] to hold the faith of Abraham». God is not remote from those who seek «the unknown God» in shadows and images, for God wills all to be saved (cf. 1 Tim 2,4) and those who seek God with a sincere heart can achieve eternal salvation. Nor will the necessary divine assistance be denied to those who have no explicit knowledge of God but who strive to lead a good life, which would only be possible under the action of grace. In the midst of various errors which sometimes lead people to despair, the Church must preach the good news and take zealous care to foster the missions.

Finally, paragraph 17 has the subtitle «On the Missionary Nature of the Church» and recalls that the Son of God, sent by the Father, in turn sent the apostles to preach to all nations and baptize them (cf. Matt. 28,18-20). Evangelization, guided by the Holy Spirit, gives birth to new churches, realizing the plan of the Father who made Christ the source of salvation for the whole world. Proclaiming the Gospel frees persons from error, incorporates them into Christ and helps them grow to full maturity. Whatever is good among peoples is preserved and perfected for the glory of God and the happiness of human beings. All disciples must spread the faith, but ultimately the community gathers together to offer the eucharist under the leadership of ordained ministers so that a hymn of glory may be raised up to the Creator and Father of the universe.

These new paragraphs were integrated with the other five which had

been inherited from earlier drafts into the cohesive whole that now stands as Chapter II, «The People of God». Congar published several essays which provide some further information about the historical origins of this chapter and valuable insight into their ecclesiological significance. From the historical angle, Congar recalled that as far back as March 3, 1961, Gerard Philips had suggested in a private conversation with him that the idea of the People of God could serve to show the link between Israel, Christ and the Church.⁷³ Chapter VI of the 1962 *De ecclesia* on the laity which, as we saw earlier, Congar praised, included some statements about this vision of the Church, and these were retained and augmented in the next draft of 1963 which was the basis of the lengthy discussion of the constitution *De ecclesia* in October of that year. During that debate, several bishops made comments about the Church as People of God and these, along with their written suggestions for amending the text, were the basis upon which the new Chapter II was gradually produced throughout the remainder of the second session from Oct. 30-Dec. 3, 1963 and in a special meeting of the subcommittee from Jan. 30-Feb. 9, 1964. The plenary theological commission considered and approved this new chapter in early March of 1964, and its overall acceptance by the Council took place on Sept. 17-18, 1964, at the beginning of the third session. The following month the subcommittee for Chapter II made further modifications according to the amendments suggested by the bishops in September and the *expensio modorum* of these further suggestions was finally accepted by the Council Fathers during the general congregation of Oct. 30th, less than a month before the promulgation of *Lumen gentium* on Nov. 21, 1964. That is Congar's account of the *itinerarium* which produced the chapter on the People of God. What is its theological significance?

Commenting on the decision to introduce it before those chapters dealing with the hierarchy, the laity and the religious, Congar wrote:

We believe that this decision was one of the most important made, and that chapter 2 on the People of God, as it was finally drawn up and voted by the assembly (September 17, 1964), has the greatest promise for the theological, pastoral and ecumenical future of ecclesiology.⁷⁴

For him, this is clear from the motivation for including this new chapter after the chapter «On the Mystery of the Church», which had shown the divine causes of the Church in the Trinity and the incarnation. The new chapter was intended 1) to explain what all the members of the People of God hold in common on the plane of the dignity of Christian existence,

⁷³ Cf. Y. CONGAR, «D'une Ecclésiologie», 129, confirmed also in *Mon journal*, I, 47-48. The rest of the historical detail which follows is from «D'une Ecclésiologie», 129-133.

⁷⁴ Y. CONGAR, «The People of God», in J.H. MILLER (ed.), *Vatican II*, 197.

prior to any distinctions based on office or state, 2) to show that the Christian community is expanding to include various categories of men and women who are unequally situated in relation to the fullness of life that is in Christ and of which the Church is the sacrament, and 3) to show that this same Church is in the process of constructing itself in human history. Paragraphs 9-12 deal especially with the first of these aims, paragraphs 14-16 with the second, and paragraphs 13 and 17 with the third.⁷⁵ These three aims relate to the three great values which Congar sees in Chapter II: that it gives priority to the ontology of grace, that it recognizes the full historicity of the Church and that it places the dynamic missionary nature of the Christian community in full relief.

Regarding the ontology of grace, the placement of the chapter about the People of God might at first be thought of as merely a methodological decision to treat what is generic and common to all Christians prior to that which is specific to particular groups. Congar sees much more here; its position in *Lumen gentium* emphasizes, first of all, the quality of being a disciple and the dignity attached to Christian existence, prior to any hierarchical structure or social organization in the Church.⁷⁶ He writes:

the most profound value is not what makes the Church a society, *societas inequalis, hierarchica*, but what makes it a community through the participation of a great number of people in the same goods of divine life. Hence the first value is not organization, mediatorial functions, or authority, but the Christian life itself and being a disciple.⁷⁷

As such, the placement of Chapter II represents a shift toward Christian anthropology and the grace-transformed lives of believers as the starting point for considering the nature of the Church, in contrast to what Congar calls the juridical view which tends to think of the Church primarily in terms of structures and rules.⁷⁸ In this way the fundamental equality of all Christians finds its proper expression, without denying the real differences between them, as acknowledged, for example, in LG 10's statement about the difference yet interrelation between the common priesthood of all the faithful and the ministerial priesthood. For Congar, it would be difficult to

⁷⁵ Cf. Y. CONGAR, «The Church: The People of God» in *Concilium* 1 (1965) 11.

⁷⁶ Cf. *Ibid.*, 13; Y. CONGAR, «Richesse et vérité d'une vision de l'Église comme Peuple de Dieu», in *Id.*, *Le concile de Vatican II*, 109; and Y. CONGAR, «The People of God» in J.H. MILLER (ed.), *Vatican II*, 198.

⁷⁷ «The People of God» in J.H. MILLER (ed.), *Vatican II*, 200.

⁷⁸ So Y. CONGAR, «The People of God» in J.H. MILLER (ed.), *Vatican II*, 199. In *Le concile au jour le jour. Troisième session*, Paris, 1965, 39, Congar notes that it is not a question of eliminating all consideration of the Church as a juridical organism, but rather of giving due priority to its sacramental-ontological dimension and of harmonizing the juridical aspect with that more primordial aspect.

overstate the importance of granting priority to the ontology of grace. In his view, one of the greatest achievements of Vatican II is to overcome the predominantly juridical understanding of the Church, which had held sway over Catholic ecclesiology for several centuries and which constituted the principal reason why the Church appeared unattractive to people today.⁷⁹

Viewing the Church as the People of God also emphasizes its rootedness in history, as part of the unfolding plan of salvation so well sketched out in some of the paragraphs for which Congar was particularly responsible (9, 13 and 17). Historicity holds two particularly important ecclesiological values for Congar. First, it makes room for human failure, growth and reform. Acknowledging that the Church is made up of human beings whose story unfolds over time and has not yet reached its fulfillment and perfection frees one from that ecclesial triumphalism which so easily can result from a view which looks only to the divine origins and influences upon the Christian community. Perhaps because of his deep appreciation for the genuine spiritual and pastoral motivation of Martin Luther and other leaders of the Protestant reform, Congar always championed the view that the Church was in need of constant reform.⁸⁰ He ventured the estimation that *Lumen gentium* may be the first Church document which speaks of eschatology in a way which allows for a dialectical presence both of holiness and sinfulness within the Christian community.⁸¹ A second great value of emphasizing the historicity of the Church is that it clears the path for a positive view of diversity and of understanding the catholicity of the Church as a communion of local churches, each with its own tradition stemming from the encounter of the Gospel with the particular genius of peoples in diverse times and places. Already in his first book, from 1937, Congar includes a masterful chapter about catholicity, in which he contrasts that deformed vision captured so well in Dostoevsky's story of the Grand Inquisitor, where catholicity is reduced to a quantitative numerical whole upon which uniformity is imposed by a dominating authority, to the authentic and traditional vision of catholicity in which human diversity is celebrated, the Church is thought of as the family of God and a communion of faith and love, and whose spirit is symbolized by the saint whom the liturgy has called the *vir catholicus*, Francis of Assisi.⁸²

⁷⁹ I have argued that this was his view in my «Yves Congar al Vaticano II», 66-67.

⁸⁰ Cf. his *Martin Luther: sa foi, sa réforme*, Paris, 1983, and *Vraie et fausse réforme dans l'Église*, Paris, 1950.

⁸¹ Cf. «The People of God» in J.H. MILLER (ed.), *Vatican II*, 202.

⁸² Cf. *Chrétiens désunis*, Paris, 1937, 135-137, on Dostoevsky's Grand Inquisitor from Chapter V of Book V of *The Brothers Karamazov*, and 137-148, for the view of catholicity as exemplified by St. Francis.

Finally, the dynamic missionary nature of the Church as a community which reaches out to all human beings as an instrument of salvation comes more into focus when one sees it as the People of God. God chooses and elects a people and establishes a covenant with it, not simply to bestow a special privilege on that people, but always to serve the wider plan of salvation. Election and mission go together.⁸³ Being consecrated to God entails dedication to his praise, witness, service and helping others to share in that same consecration. The People of God is the people of the promise; the present fulfillment of God's promise gives hope for that fulfillment which yet lies in the future. As such, the People of God is «a most sure seed of unity, hope and salvation for the whole human race» (LG 9). Within this context, Congar rejoices in the fact that paragraphs 13-17 of *Lumen gentium* seek to find a more satisfying language than that of «Church membership», of which Pius XII made use in *Mystici corporis*, but which suggests a sharp either/or evaluation of the relation of any particular individual to the Church. Instead, LG 13 concludes by affirming that all human beings are «called to this catholic unity» and «in different ways [...] belong or are related» to it. In this way, Congar believes that the language of membership is superseded by a language of 'communion', full or imperfect when speaking about baptized Christians, and by a language of 'relation', when speaking about those who are not baptized.⁸⁴

«A Few Other Particular Passages». It is difficult to establish what other passages Congar refers to in his statement about his contributions to *Lumen gentium*. For Chapter III, we know that he wrote a *votum* entitled *De Episcopis, et in primis de eorum Relatione ad totam Ecclesiam*, which he submitted to the preparatory theological commission, but his diary entries suggest that his opinions expressed therein were not taken up.⁸⁵ As indicated above, he was very disappointed that most of the *modi* which he and several colleagues had prepared in August, 1964, in order to make Chapter III more appealing to the Orthodox were not adopted. However, several of his suggestions which had been submitted by the French bishops were accepted and modified paragraph 28 on priests, by relating their priesthood

⁸³ Cf. «The Church: The People of God», 19-24.

⁸⁴ Cf. «The People of God» in J.H. MILLER (ed.), *Vatican II*, 203-204, and Congar's discussion comments printed in the same volume on page 232. See also J. PUVO, *Une vie pour la vérité*, 127. That the Secretariat for Unity was urging such a shift in language already during the first session is clear from Congar's entry of Oct. 28, 1962, in *Mon journal*, I, 155-156.

⁸⁵ This text is described and parts of it are quoted in H. SCHAUF, *Das Leitungsamt der Bischöfe. Zur Textgeschichte der Konstitution «Lumen Gentium» des II. Vatikanischen Konzils*, München – Paderborn – Wien, 1975, 15-19. Schauf also records some of Congar's interventions during the discussion at that early stage on pages 50-52, 105 and 107. Schauf remarks on page 19 that the five *vota* on bishops (Michel, Congar, Tromp, Doronzo and Schultze) sharply disagreed with one another.

more directly to that of Christ.⁸⁶

Regarding Chapter IV, on the Laity, an examination of the various synopses available shows that a significant amount of Chapter VI, *De laicis*, of the original *De ecclesia* of 1962, made it to the final text of *Lumen gentium*. Earlier we saw that Congar recognized much of his *votum* on the laity in this preparatory draft which had been written by Msgr. Philips. Regarding Chapters V on the universal call to holiness and VI on religious, there is little evidence that Congar had any hand, except a reference to working on the *modi* which had been submitted for those chapters in late September, 1964.⁸⁷ From the official Acts of Vatican II, we know that Congar was assigned to work on Chapter VII; his diary entries show him doing so in commission meetings in June and August of 1964.⁸⁸ The discussion of this draft by the Council Fathers on Sept. 15-16, 1964, criticized the text for being too individualistic and spiritual and for lacking any reference to the wider historical and cosmic dimensions of eschatology, criticisms which had already been voiced during the meeting of the theological commission the previous month. Congar was asked to introduce these dimensions into the draft, a task which he finished on Sept. 27th. They appear mainly in LG 48, the first paragraph of Chapter VII, and were approved in substance on October 20th.⁸⁹ Congar seems not to have had any direct role in the fashioning of Chapter VIII on Mary.

Conclusion

Congar's evaluation of the results of the council was not naively optimistic. In an article on the relation of Vatican II to theology, he pointed out the need for much further work on the following themes: how the communion of disciples rests upon a sacramental basis, the relation of the local and universal church, the theology of ministry, the role of women in Church life, the way in which the primatial authority of the Bishop of Rome functions within the communion of the Churches and collegiality. In many ways, he concluded, Vatican II remained only a beginning; it only went half way.⁹⁰ His first studies about collegiality, for example, were based upon Russian ideas about the synodality of the Church which Congar took up in his book on the

⁸⁶ Cf. *Mon journal*, II, 232 and 405; on the latter page he writes: «Ceux [*modi*] que j'ai rédigés, que les évêques français ont demandés, que la commission a acceptés, ont suffi à modifier profondément l'allure, l'équilibre, et donc la doctrine de ce n° 28. Cela a été une de mes pauvres joies».

⁸⁷ Cf. *Mon journal*, II, 160.

⁸⁸ See above, note 52, and *Mon journal*, II, 114 and 121.

⁸⁹ Cf. *Ibid.*, 135-136 for the debate and 164-165 for the vote.

⁹⁰ Y. CONGAR, «Les théologiens, Vatican II et la théologie» in *Le concile du Vatican II*, 79-98 at 81-84.

laity, in 1953.⁹¹ He believed that they too needed to be considered within the framework of collegiality; at Vatican II, it proved no simple task to affirm only the collegiality of bishops!

At the same time he greatly appreciated some of the important advances achieved by the Council, chief among which were the overcoming of the defensive posture of the Counter-Reformation and the shift from a juridical to a more sacramental-ontological understanding of the Church.⁹² He writes of the «immense and nearly inexhaustible riches» of *Lumen gentium*: its recognition that everything in the Church, from its origin to its final destiny, depends on God and is for the sake of all human beings; its description of the new creation which is the Church within an historical and eschatological context; its ontology of grace over juridical structure; its preference for categories of participation and communion over those of membership; its awareness of the pilgrim status of the community in view of the kingdom of God; its biblical and patristic foundations; its affirmation of episcopal collegiality; its ecumenical sensitivity; and its relating Mary to Jesus and to the life of His Church.⁹³

At the solemn opening liturgy Congar gazed around St. Peter's and noticed the statues of the great founders of religious orders which grace the walls of that basilica. If only the statues could speak, he thought. What would they say? «I imagine them speaking as men and women of God, burning with the fire of the gospel,» he wrote.⁹⁴ He was always convinced that the heart of Christianity can be found in the unique relationship with God and with other human beings made possible through the gospel words and saving deeds of Jesus Christ. In a way, his painful experience of being under suspicion during the years prior to Vatican II reinforced his perception that a certain kind of ecclesiology, focused upon the affirmation of a central authority which dominated and enforced uniformity, contradicted what he believed about the relationships which are the essence of discipleship and of the Church.

After he returned from his mother's funeral, Congar mused about why it sometimes happens that a priest or religious leaves the ministry or the community after the death of his mother. Some may venture that such a person waited for that death before leaving, in order to spare his parent the sadness which that departure might cause. Right after his own mother's death Congar offered another explanation. Perhaps one waited because, until that time, the priest or religious always felt he had a place where he

⁹¹ See his comments his article «The Laity» in J.H. MILLER (ed.), *Vatican II*, 247-248, and *Entretiens d'automne*, Paris, 1987, 19-20.

⁹² See his remarks in *Le concile au jour le jour. Quatrième session*, Paris, 1966, 128-131.

⁹³ These ideas come from *Ibid.*, 133-134.

⁹⁴ *Mon journal*, I, 106.

was unconditionally accepted and loved and people whom he could love without complication or restraint.⁹⁵ A powerful testimony to this link between Congar's suffering in the Church and the support he felt from his mother is the long letter he wrote to her on the occasion of her 80th birthday, in 1956, when he was still 'exiled' in Cambridge, England, having been dismissed from teaching several years earlier.⁹⁶ It is a poignant cry from the heart. Perhaps what he himself might hope could be his most important contribution to *Lumen gentium* would be its teaching that the Church is a people called together by the love of the Father and living with one another in relationships of mutual respect and love.

Pontificia Università Gregoriana
Piazza della Pilotta, 4
00187 Roma

William HENN OFM Cap.

⁹⁵ Cf. *Mon journal*, I, 576-577, for the very moving expression of love and grief at the loss of his mother on the part of the then fifty-nine year old Congar.

⁹⁶ «Lettre du père Congar à sa mère, présentée et annotée par Étienne Fouilloux,» in *La vie spirituelle*, 154 (2000) 135-144.

SUMMARY

This article attempts to bring more clearly into light Yves Congar's contribution to *Lumen gentium*. During the preparatory period of the council, Congar contributed some *vota* which influenced the *De ecclesia* schema of 1962, but more important were his theological publications which helped form the ecclesiological vision of many bishops. During Vatican II, his informal contribution through unofficial meetings and lectures gradually was replaced by a direct role in drafting and revising texts. His influence can be seen principally in the first two chapters of *Lumen gentium*, rendering it more biblical and patristic and placing into relief 1) the priority of grace over structure, 2) the historicity of the Church, giving better expression to its humanity and catholicity, and 3) its essentially missionary nature.

Questo articolo intende mettere in una luce più chiara il contributo di Yves Congar alla Costituzione *Lumen gentium*. Durante il periodo preparatorio del concilio, Congar ha scritto alcuni *vota* che avevano qualche incidenza sul *De ecclesia* del 1962, ma più significative furono le sue pubblicazioni teologiche lette da molti vescovi. Dopo l'inizio del concilio, il suo contributo informale attraverso incontri e conferenze fu aumentato gradualmente da un ruolo più ufficiale nell'incarico di scrivere stesure di testi. Il suo influsso principale appare nei primi due capitoli della *Lumen gentium*, rendendoli più biblici e più patristici, e dando più enfasi 1) sulla priorità della grazia rispetto alla struttura istituzionale, 2) sulla storicità della Chiesa, esprimendone meglio la natura umana e la cattolicità, e 3) sulla sua essenziale missionarietà.